EXPLORING ETHICS AND MORAL PERSPECTIVES ON AI IN CULTURAL COLLECTIONS

building a web resource to help navigate this complex and ever-changing landscape – links available in notes

Dr Maeve Murphy Quinlan

CHATHAM HOUSE RULE

Participants are free to use any information shared, but should not reveal the identity or affiliation of any speaker/participant

* As the facilitator, I am happy for anything I share to be shared and attributed to me

WHAT VALUES DO YOU HOLD MOST IMPORTANT IN YOUR WORK?

- A rapid, gut-feeling-guided exercise
- Pick 5 core values
  - I'll put up a list of ideas/possibilities, but you can absolutely add your own!
  - Don't second guess yourself
  - Scribble them down on a piece of paper
- Specifically around the possible use of AI in your area/field (some examples on the next slide might not be relevant at all!)
- What values drive your approach to cultural collections?

Accountability Achievement Adaptability Adventure Altruism Ambition Authenticity Balance Beauty Being the best Belonging Career Caring Collaboration Commitment Community Compassion Competence Confidence Connection Contentment Contribution Cooperation Courage Creativity Curiosity Dignity Diversity Environment Efficiency Equality Excellence Fairness Forgiveness Freedom Friendship Fun Future generations Generosity Giving back Grace Gratitude Growth Harmony Health Home Honesty Hope Humility Humor Inclusion Independence Initiative Integrity Intuition Job security Joy Justice Kindness Knowledge Leadership Learning Legacy Loyalty Making a difference Nature Openness Optimism Order Parenting Patience Patriotism Peace Perseverance Personal fulfillment Power Pride Recognition Reliability Resourcefulness Respect Responsibility Risk-taking Safety Security Self-discipline Self-expression Self-respect Serenity Service Simplicity Spirituality Sportsmanship Stewardship Success Teamwork Thrift Time Tradition Trust Truth Understanding Uniqueness Usefulness Vision Vulnerability Well-being Wholeheartedness Wisdom

Did you pick 5 values?

- You have **30 seconds** to discard two
  - Cross out the 2 least important!

- You have **30 seconds** to discard another two
  - Leave just a *single guiding value*!

JOIN THE VEVOX SESSION

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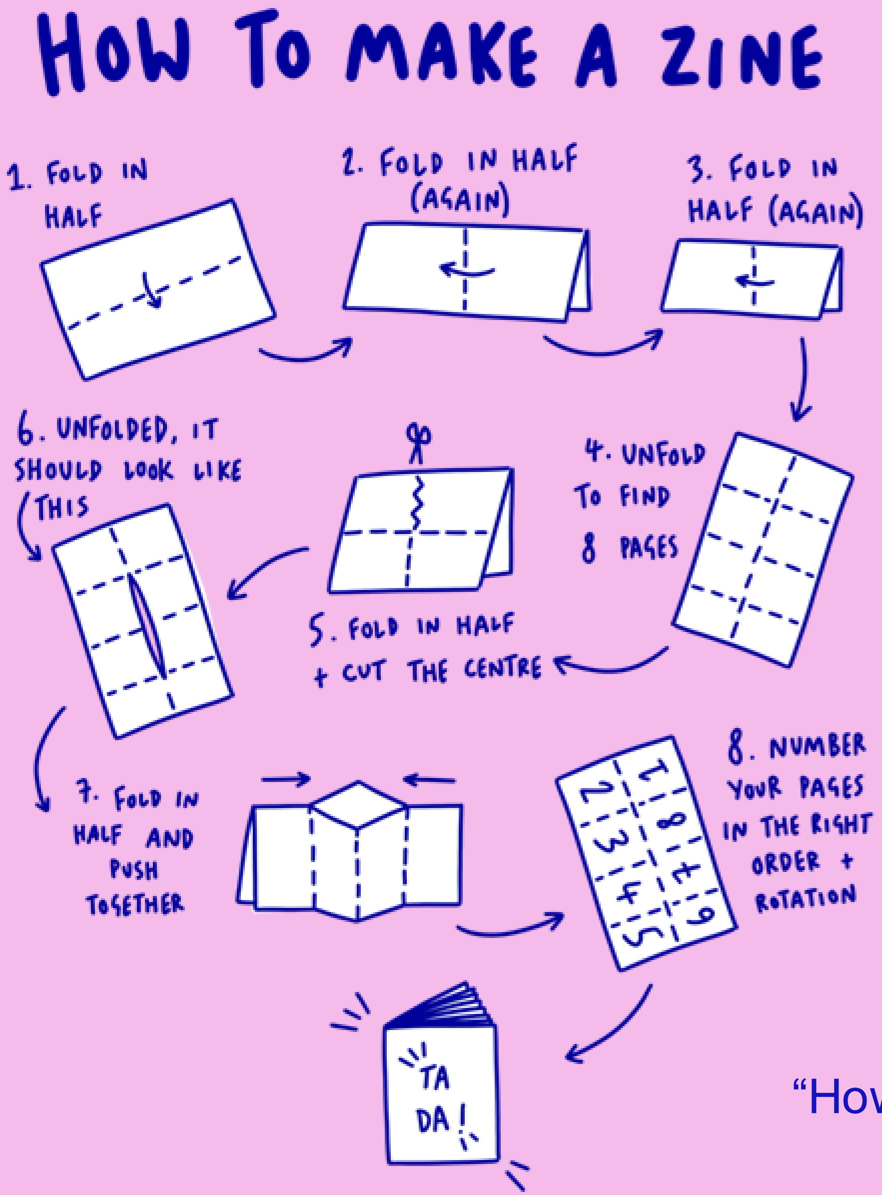
WHAT IS YOUR GUIDING VALUE?



We'll add to this throughout the workshop!

Add your guiding value to the front cover as a title:

- [value] & the use of AI
- [value] when assessing AI use
- Or something else entirely!

"How to make a zine" by Daisy Wakefield, 42nd Street Charity

Where do you fit?

When it comes to your feelings on the use of AI, where do you find yourself sitting?

Which figure in this drawing do you most relate to, and why?

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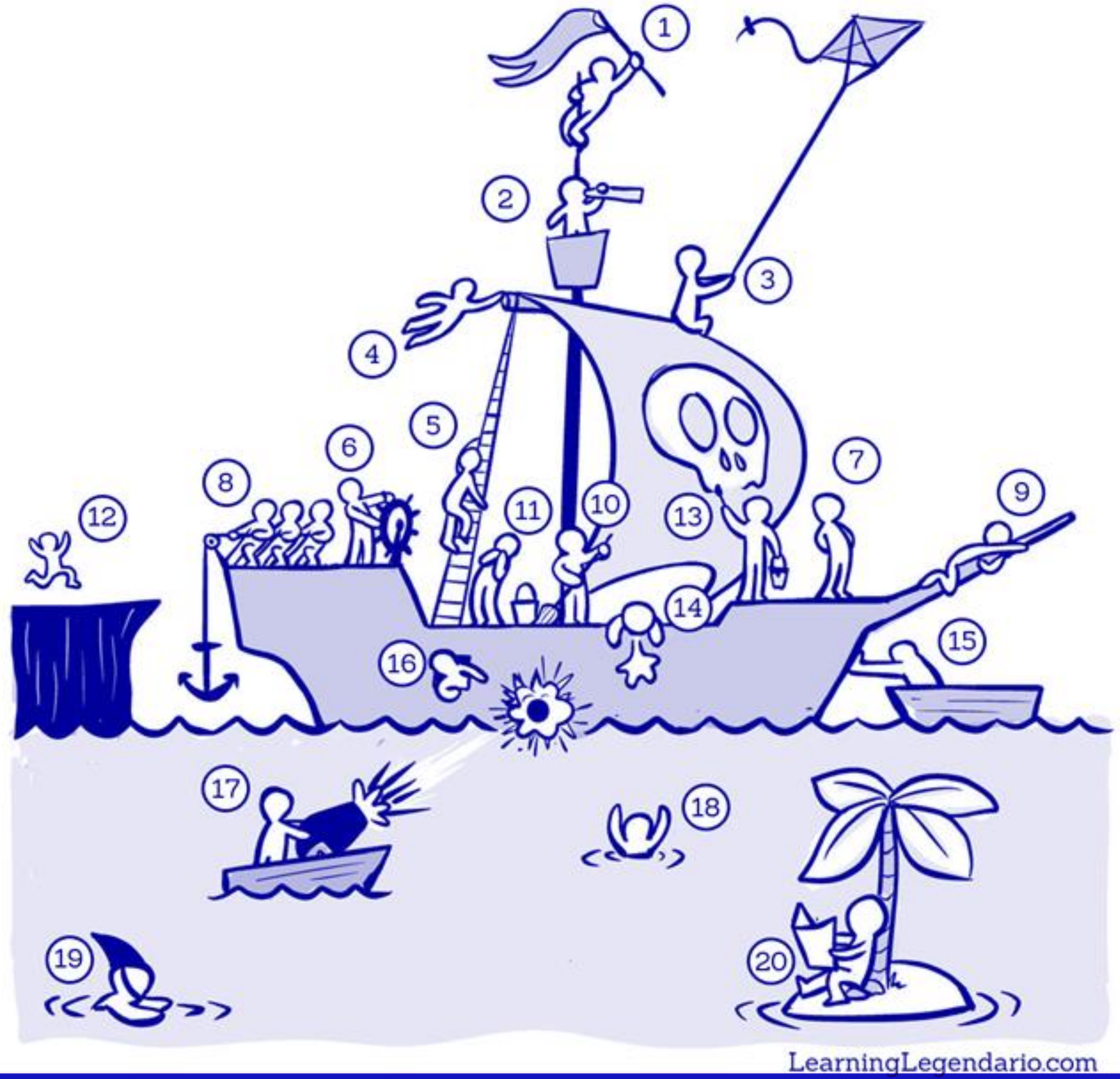
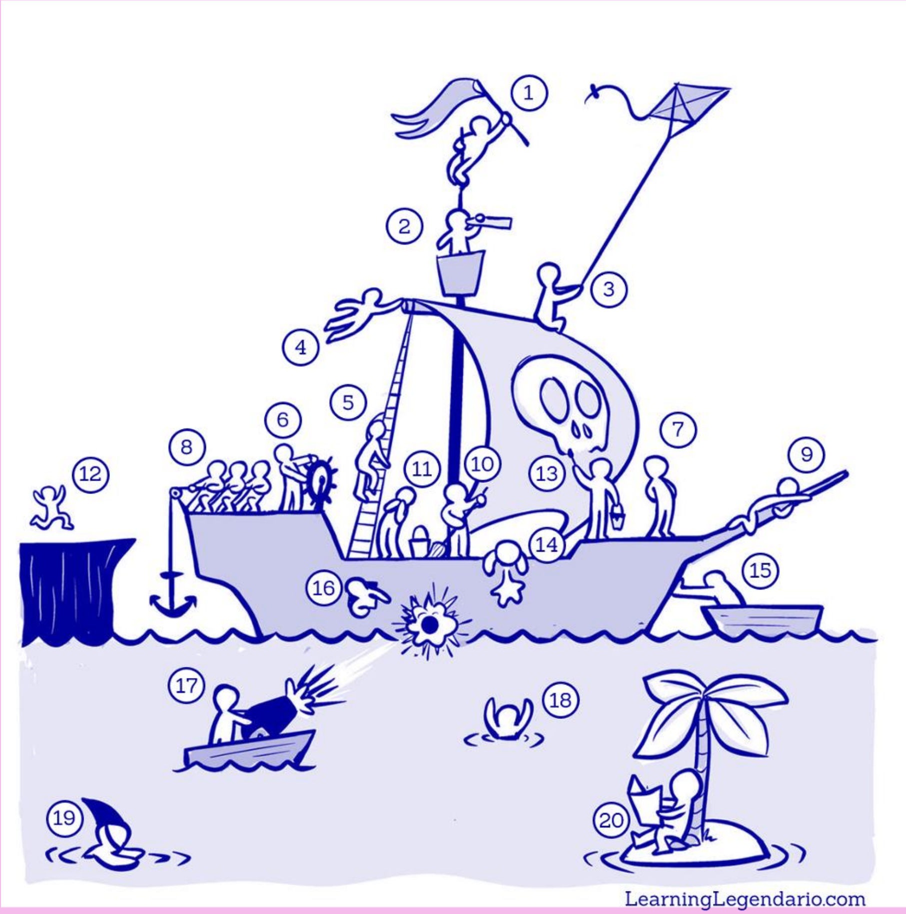


WHICH FIGURE DO YOU FEEL REPRESENTS YOU AND YOUR RELATIONSHIP TO AI? PLEASE LIST THE NUMBER AND A BRIEF EXPLANATION WHY THIS REPRESENTS YOU.THERE IS NO SINGLE CORRECT INTERPRETATION OF ANY OF THE FIGURES/ACTIVITIES.



MOTIVATING QUESTIONS

- How do we create an intentional, shared framework for ethical AI use, when the technology is so sprawling and ever changing?
- How do we reconcile building cohesive guidelines for practitioners with our contrasting positionalities and their effect on our moral stance on various AI uses?
- How do we reconcile pragmatism with idealism in our modes of interaction with AI?
- Can we balance social good and potential harms? Should we?

PULSE CHECK

How familiar are you with different aspects of AI technologies, and the ethical implications of their use?

HOW FAMILIAR ARE YOU WITH THE FOLLOWING TOPICS?

This is new to me! — I'm very knowledgable on this

The "AI tech stack" (models, data, compute underpinning AI)

LLMs/Large Language Models

"Small" Language Models (SLMs)

Computer vision

Machine learning

HOW FAMILIAR ARE YOU WITH THE FOLLOWING TOPICS?

This is new to me! I'm very knowledgable on this

FAIR data principles

CARE data principles

Open Research

Reproducibility, reusability, replicability

HOW FAMILIAR ARE YOU WITH THE FOLLOWING TOPICS?

This is new to me! I'm very knowledgable on this

Ethics of 'classification' as a method/approach

Data feminism

Data & digital sovereignty

WHAT DO YOU EVEN *MEAN* BY AI?

A marketing buzz word, a shunned term, a broad umbrella category?

WHAT IS AI?

DEFINITIONS THAT HELP US ADDRESS ETHICS

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is **“The capacity of computers or other machines to exhibit or simulate intelligent behaviour; the field of study concerned with this.”** (OED, 3rd edn., Dec 2021). This includes a range of techniques commonly used in research to find patterns in complex data, including machine learning and generative AI.

WHAT IS AI?

DEFINITIONS THAT HELP US ADDRESS ETHICS

Artificial intelligence is neither artificial
nor intelligent. Rather, artificial
intelligence is both em... and
material, made from ...
fuel, human la...
logistics, histo...

AI systems ar...
rational, or a...
without exte...
intensive traini...
predefined rules...

In fact, artificial i...
it depends entirely on a...
of political and social struc...
to the capital required to buil... at scale
and the ways of seeing that it optimizes
AI systems are ultimately designed to
serve existing dominant interests.

In this sense, artificial intelligence is a registry of power.

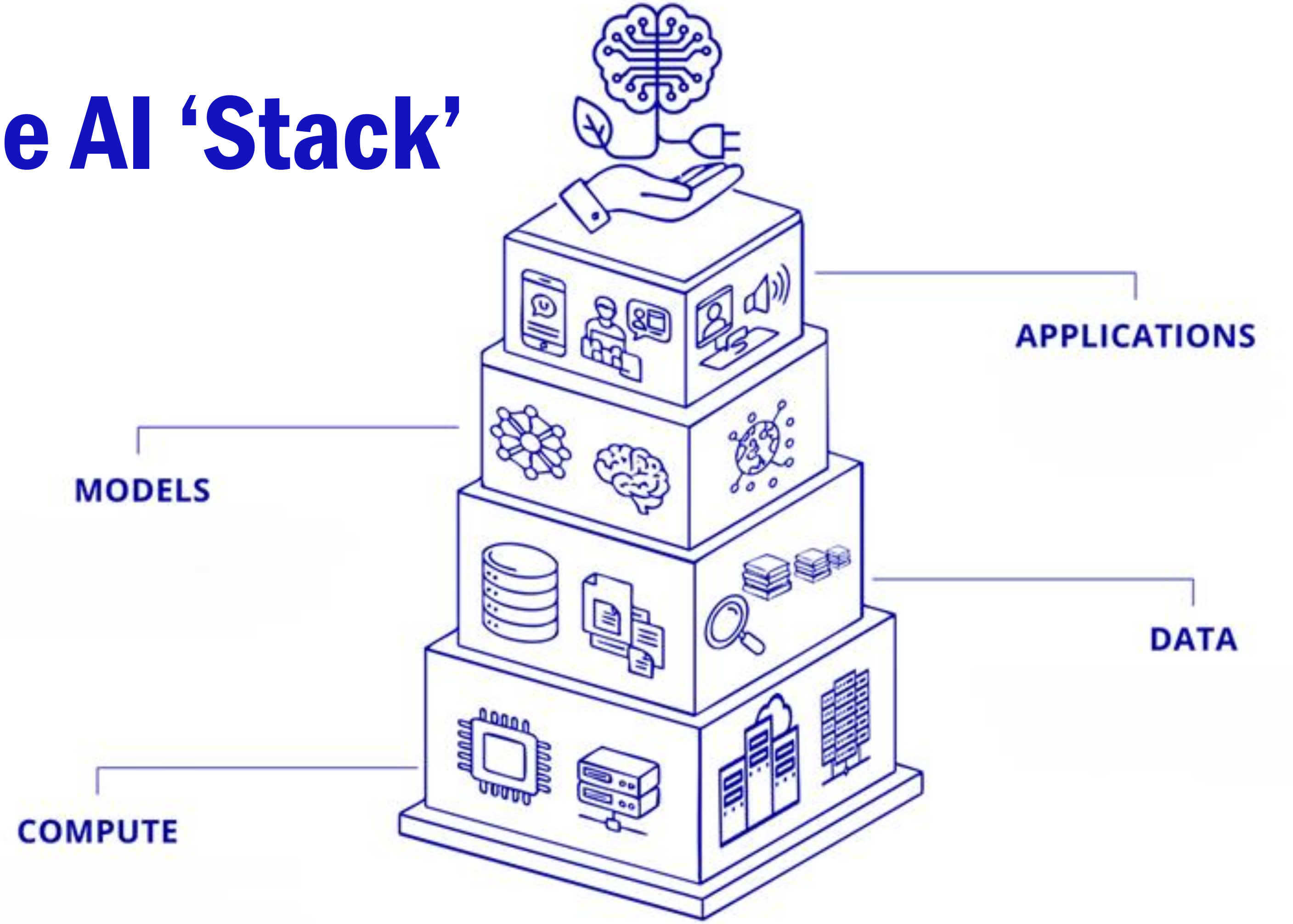
Kate Crawford, Atlas of AI

How can we challenge this power?
Can we implement AI in ways and means which subvert these dominant interests?
Is ethical AI possible?

‘AI’ IS AS SPECIFIC AS THE TERM ‘VEHICLE’

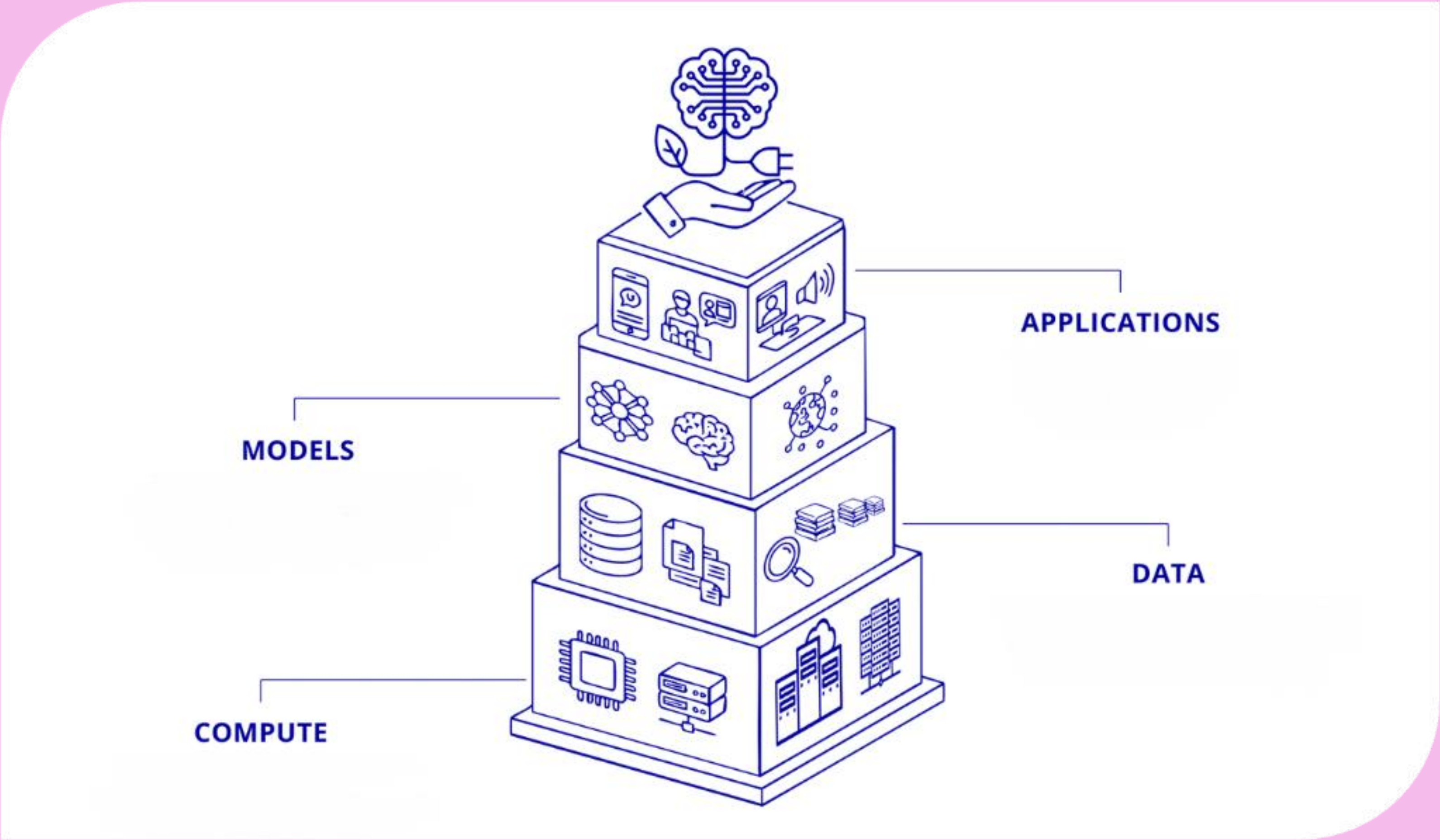
- *AI Snake Oil: What Artificial Intelligence Can Do, What It Can’t, and How to Tell the Difference*, Arvind Narayanan & Sayash Kapoor
- Vehicles, vs…
  - Cars
  - Private jets
  - Ambulance
  - Kayaks
  - School buses
  - Military tanks
  - Push bikes
  - Mega yachts

The AI 'Stack'



Sichani, A.-M. (2026). 'Responsible AI in Cultural Heritage'. RESHAPED. School of Advanced Study, University of London. https://reshaped.sas.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=129 shared under CC BY-NC-SA 40.

WHICH ASPECT OF THE 'AI STACK' DO YOU THINK IS MOST RELEVANT TO YOUR SPECIFIC ROLE?



WHAT IS ETHICAL RESEARCH?

ETHICAL RESEARCH

“a set of principles and practices that prioritise the well-being and rights of all individuals involved in the research process, as well as the broader society”

“characterised by a commitment to **the well-being and rights of participants**, a **transparent and responsible approach**, and **adherence to established ethical principles** and guidelines”

University of Leeds, Policies Procedues and Codes of Practice

IS AN ETHICS REVIEW REQUIRED?

Research that involves the following needs ethical review:

- Human participants (including all types of interviews, questionnaires, focus groups, records relating to humans, use of online datasets or other secondary data, observation, etc.)
- Social media and/or data from internet sources that could be regarded as private.
- The risk to members of the research team, such as: lone working; travel to areas where researchers may be at risk; risk of emotional distress.
- Threat to the environment.
- Where research projects involve information freely available in the public domain (e.g. published biographies, newspaper accounts) and the analysis of datasets, either open source or obtained from other researchers, you may need to apply for ethical review if you are not able to verify that the data are properly anonymised and informed consent was obtained at the time of original data collection.

University of Leeds Secretariat

- But many possible applications/uses of AI in the GLAM sector may not constitute full formal research projects
- Ai tooling is becoming more and more unavoidable, built into everyday systems:
  - Increasingly easy to engage with uncritically
- How do we support informal, smaller scale ‘ethics checks’?

ETHICAL PRINCIPLES

For medicine/healthcare specifically, but useful guiding ideas:

- Respect for Autonomy (the principle of self-governance)
- Beneficence (the principle of doing good)
- Nonmaleficence (the principle of avoiding harm)
- Justice (the principle of fairness)
- Accountability

PRE-EXISTING FRAMEWORKS

A small selection…

Braga, Carlos Mario, Manuel A. Serrano, and Eduardo Fernández-Medina. 2025. "Towards a Methodology for Ethical Artificial Intelligence System Development: A Necessary Trustworthiness Taxonomy." *Expert Systems With Applications* 286 (128034): 128034.

"Data and AI Ethics Framework." 2018. Gov.uk. June 13, 2018. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/data-ethics-framework. [Includes self assessment tool]

European Commission. 2026. "Living Guidelines on the Responsible Use of Generative AI in Research." 3rd ed. Brussels: European Commission. https://research-and-innovation.ec.europa.eu/document/download/2b6cf7e5-36ac-41cb-aab5-0d32050143dc_en.

Porsdam Mann, Sebastian, Anuraag A. Vazirani, Mateo Aboy, Brian D. Earp, Timo Minssen, I. Glenn Cohen, and Julian Savulescu. 2024. "Guidelines for Ethical Use and Acknowledgement of Large Language Models in Academic Writing." *Nature Machine Intelligence* 6 (11): 1272–74.

Resnik, David B., and Mohammad Hosseini. 2025. "The Ethics of Using Artificial Intelligence in Scientific Research: New Guidance Needed for a New Tool." *AI and Ethics* 5 (2): 1499–1521.

UNESCO. 2022. "Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence." SHS/BIO/PI/2021/1. https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000381137.

EXISTING RESOURCES

- Course materials:
  - **A.-M. Sichani (2026). 'Responsible AI in Cultural Heritage'. RESHAPED. School of Advanced Study, University of London. https://reshaped.sas.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=129**
- Books:
  - J. Schaich Borg, W. Sinnott-Armstrong, and V. Conitzer (2024). 'Moral AI : and how we get there'
  - K. Crawford (2022). 'Atlas of AI: Power, Politics, and the Planetary Costs of Artificial Intelligence'
- Reports:
  - Bowes, Stuart, and Frances Varley. 2025. "University Cultural Collections and Generative AI: Critical Approaches in a Library Context." Leeds: University of Leeds Libraries.

SO WHY CREATE ANOTHER?

- Technology:
  - More searchable, atomic, interlinked
- From vague statements and difficult-to-implement concepts, to a practical implementable workflow
- Recognising that these exact same ethical harms are being tackled in data science and other areas
- Taxonomical approach
- There is no “checklist” to ensure your work is ethical

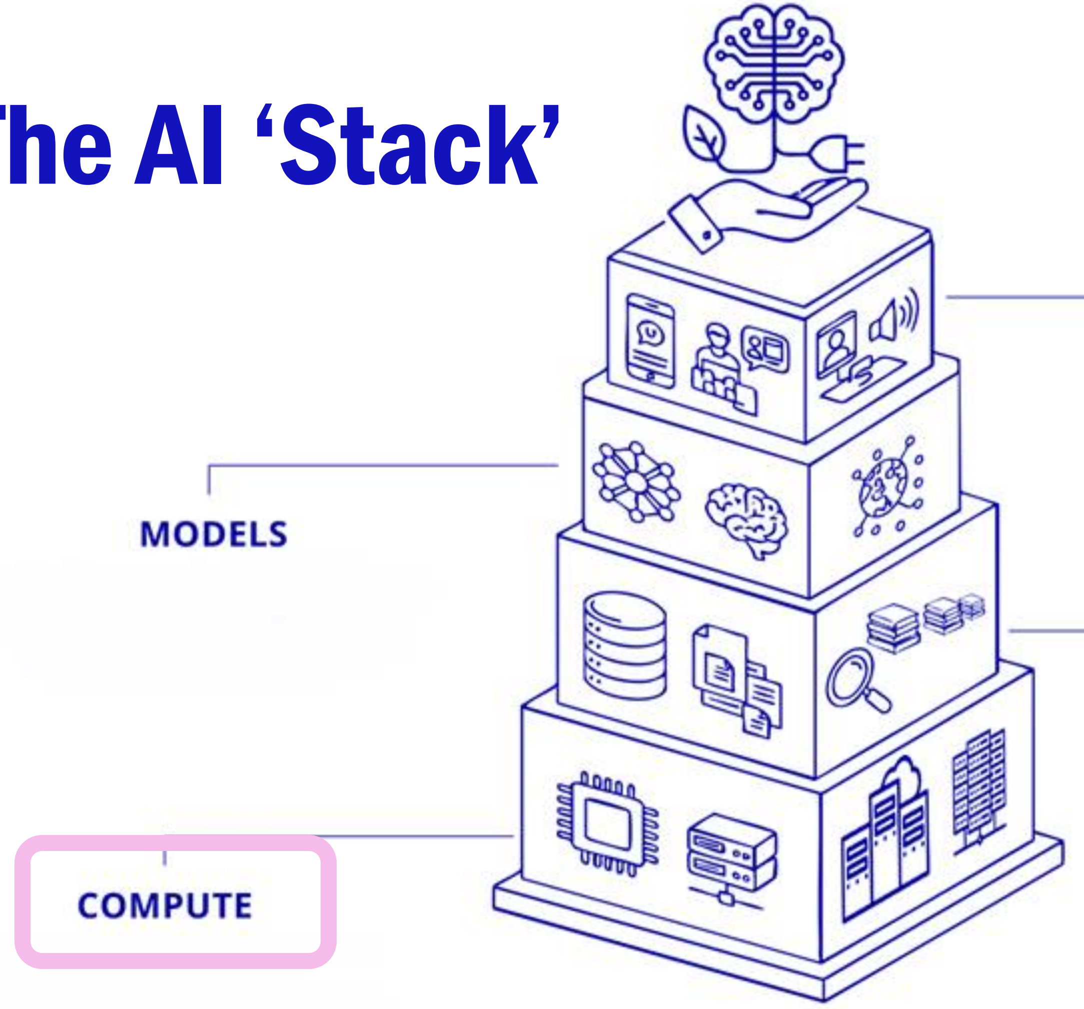
ETHICS IN AI OR ETHICS IN COMPUTATIONAL METHODS?

- "But data centres are used for other types of computation, not just AI!"
- Other fields use data about people that may not have consented to the collection of that data!
- *These concerns aren't exclusive to AI!*

I see the focus on ethics in AI as an opportunity to reasses ethical frameworks for computational research in general!

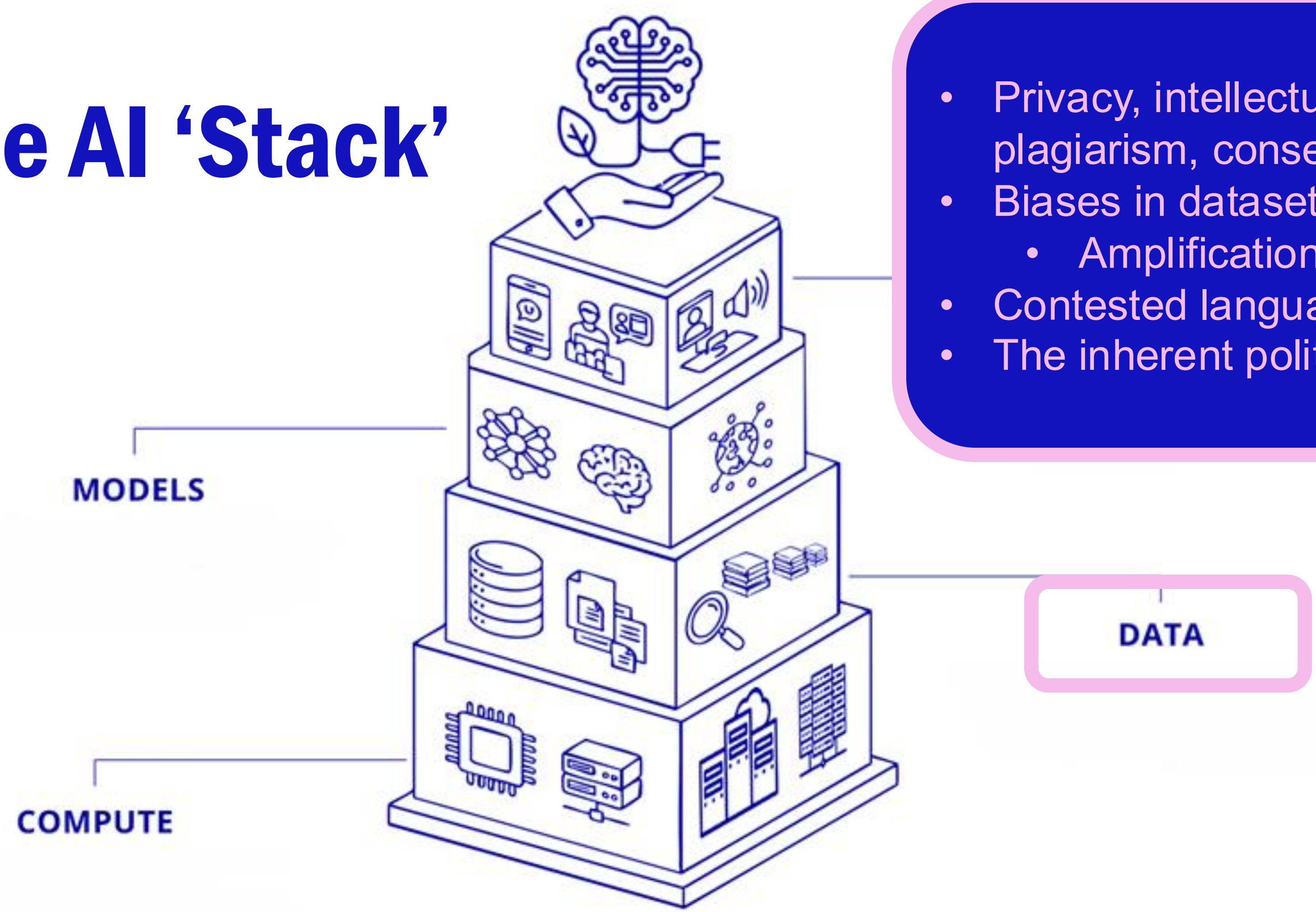
DEFINING ETHICAL CONCERNS

The AI 'Stack'



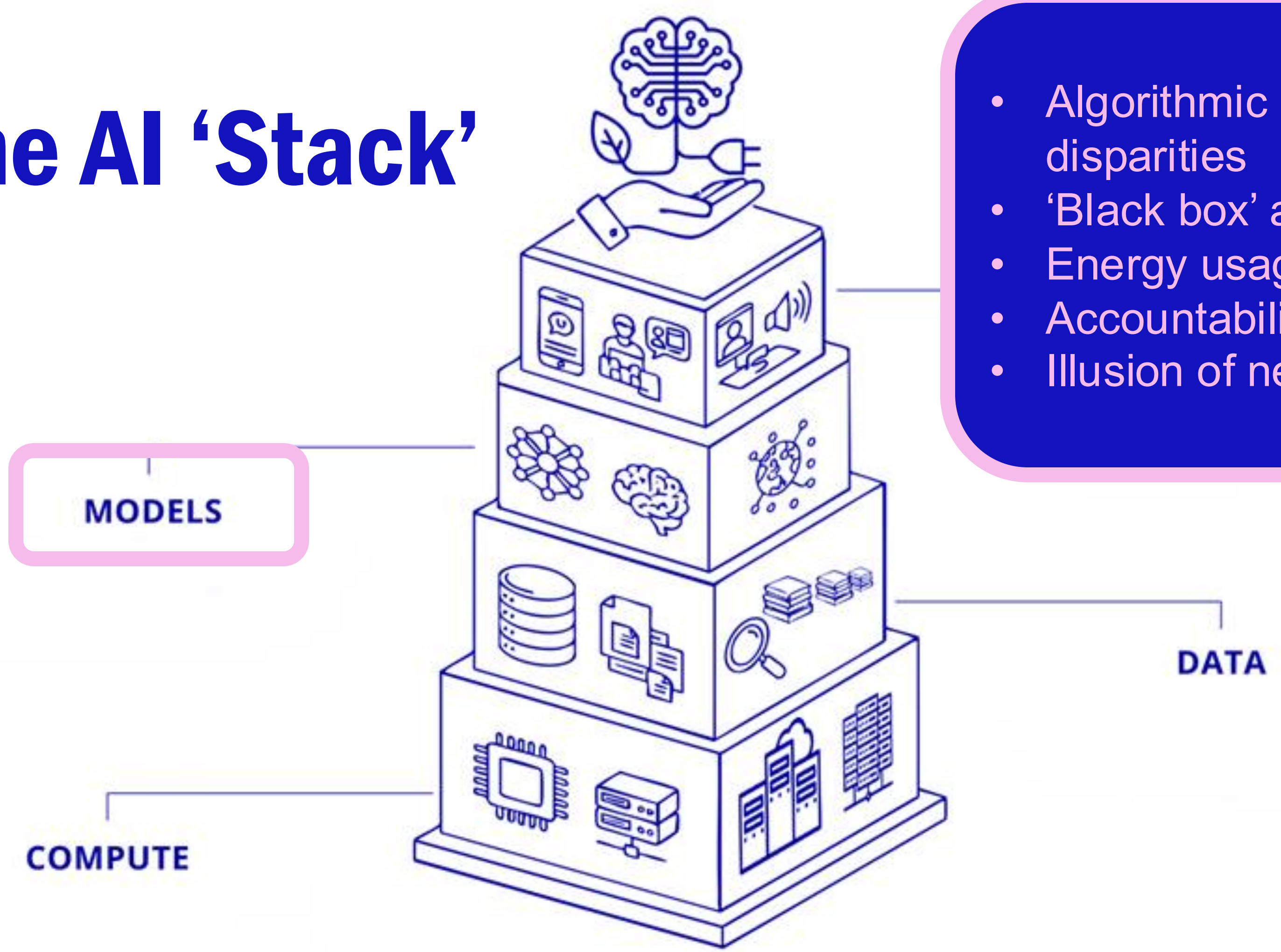
- Rapidly increasing demand for data centres, chips, etc.
  - Mining – workforce
- Environmental concerns
  - Energy
  - Water consumption
  - Polution of local area

The AI 'Stack'



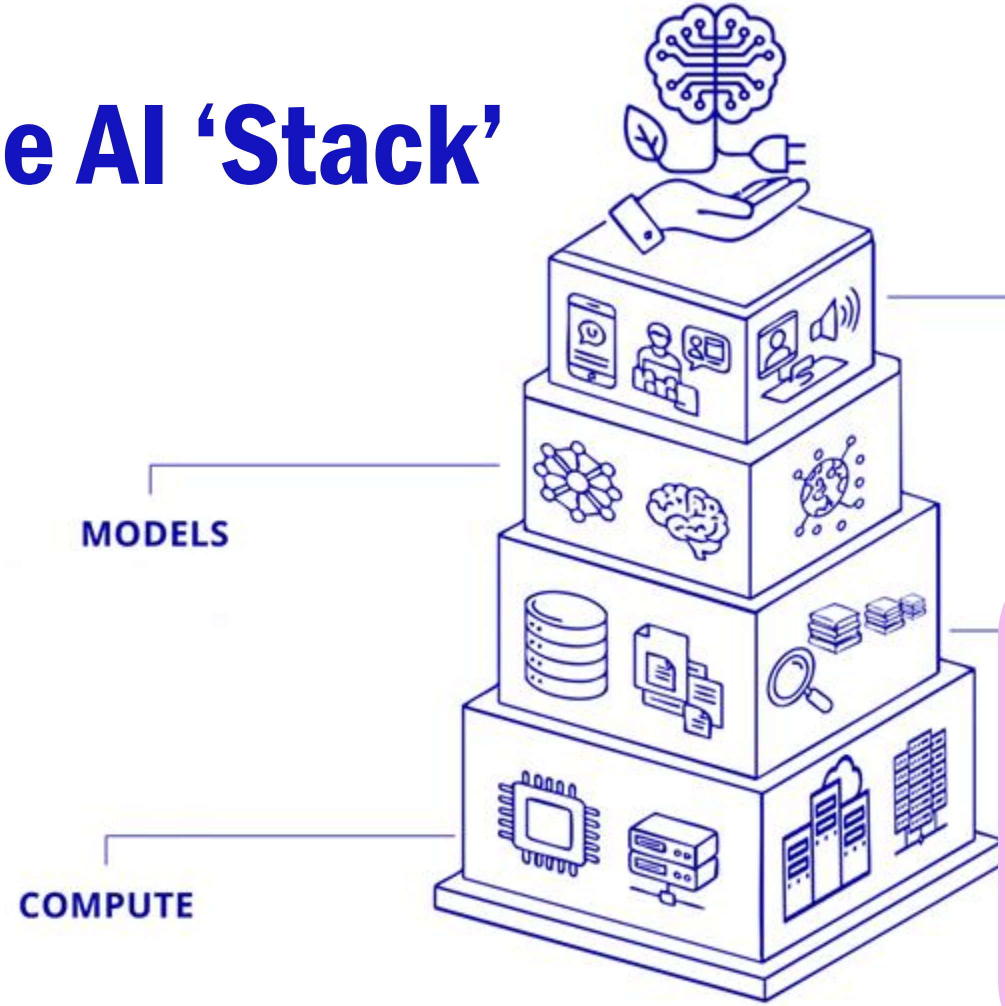
- Privacy, intellectual property, plagiarism, consent
- Biases in datasets
  - Amplification of hegemony
- Contested language
- The inherent politics of classification

The AI 'Stack'



- Algorithmic bias amplifying existing disparities
- 'Black box' algorithms
- Energy usage
- Accountability for model output?
- Illusion of neutral, logical output

The AI 'Stack'



- Overreliance and deskilling:
  - Reduced ability to assess outputs
- Currently economically unsustainable
  - AI token bills vs. human infrastructure?
- Focus on optimization of workflow and increased output as end goal

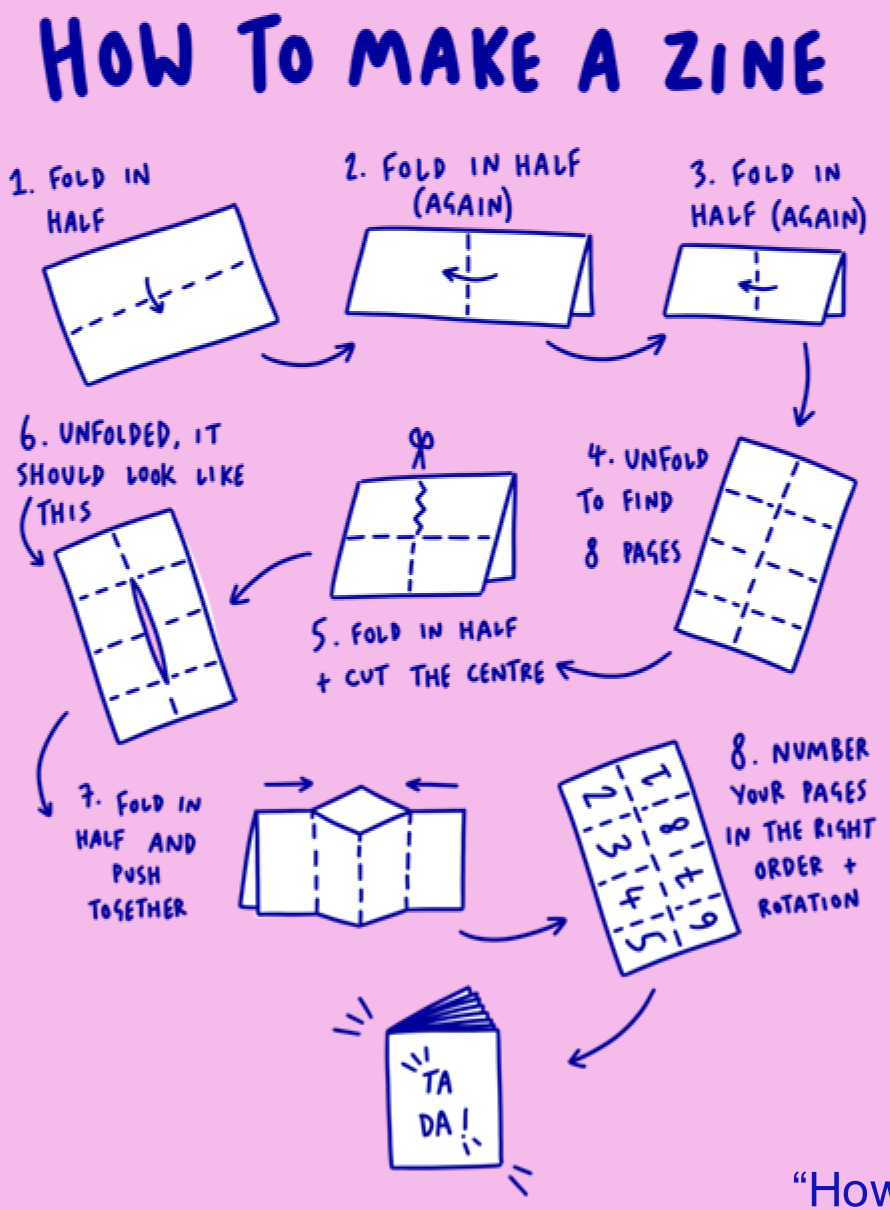
CASE STUDY: HARVARD ART MUSEUM

Example 1

Example 2

WHAT SCALE OF CHANGE IS NEEDED TO ADDRESS THESE CONCERNS?

Are they approachable on an individual level, with workflow changes? Do they require a research group or collaborative effort? Do they require large scale, international regulation? Do they require a fundamental shift in economic system/social incentive structure?



Putting on a critical/cautious hat

On the first page of the zine, add a few of the key ethical harms you believe are relevant to your specific practice

What “scale” of input is needed to address these concerns, on a scale from personal all the way to global? Is this feasible?

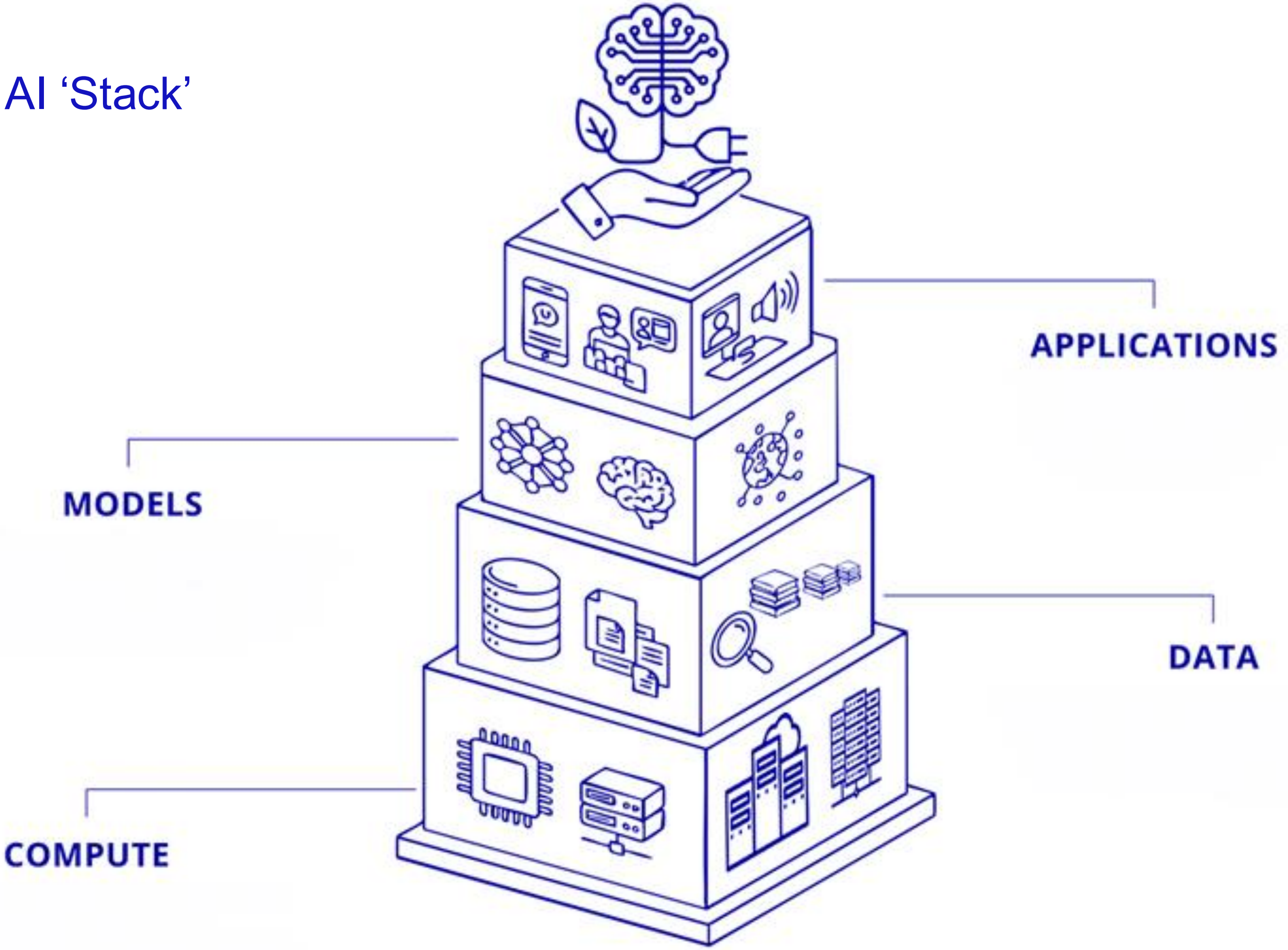
“How to make a zine” by Daisy Wakefield, 42nd Street Charity

WHAT DO YOU THINK ARE THE BIGGEST ETHICAL RISKS/HARMS OF AI TODAY? WHAT SCALE OF CHANGE IS NEEDED?

SO WHAT MIGHT WE BE ABLE TO LEARN FROM FRAMEWORKS IN COMPUTATIONAL RESEARCH?

- Open Research
- FAIR data
- CARE data
- Data Feminism
- Data activism
- Liberatory Computation

The AI ‘Stack’



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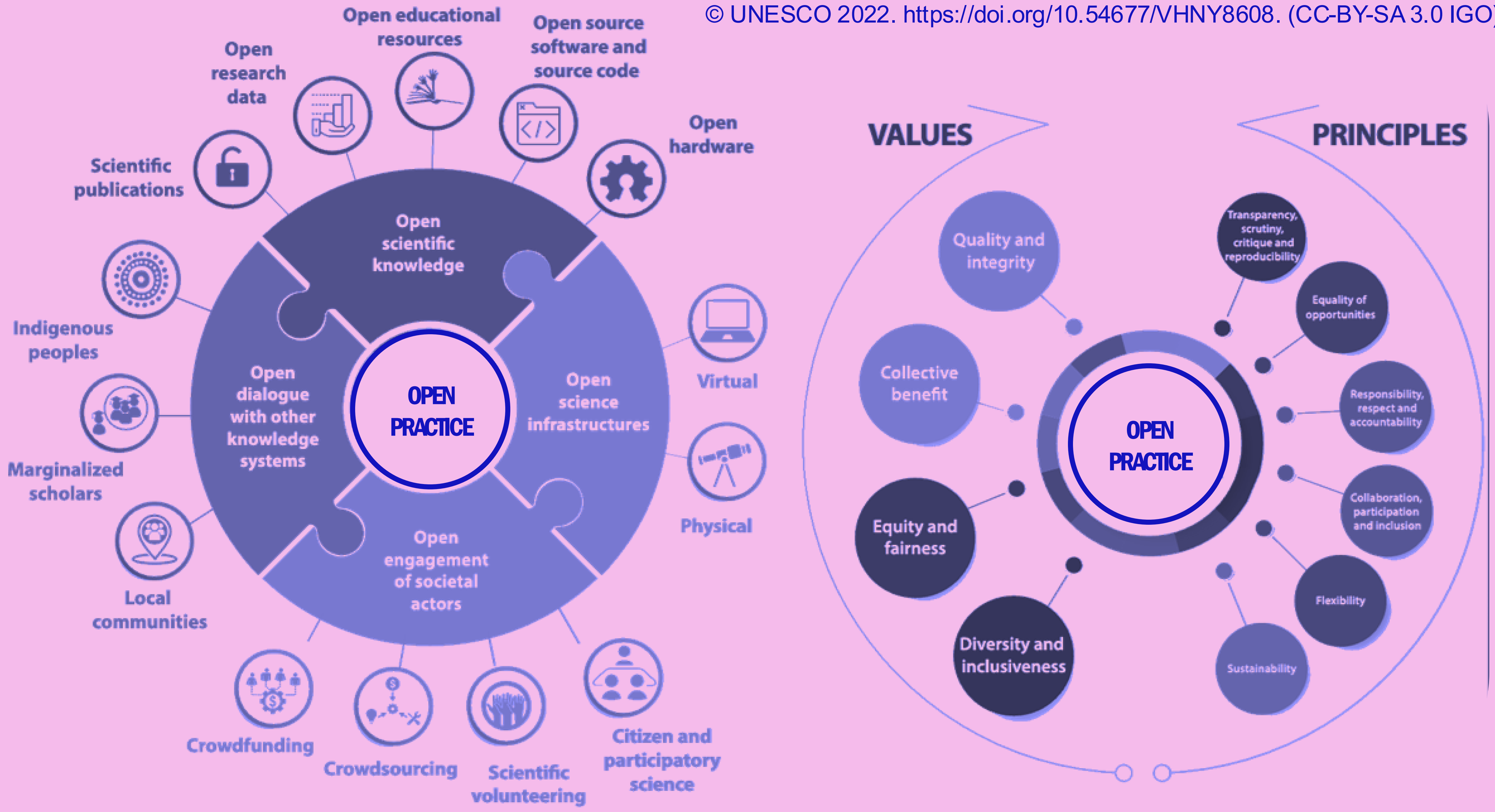
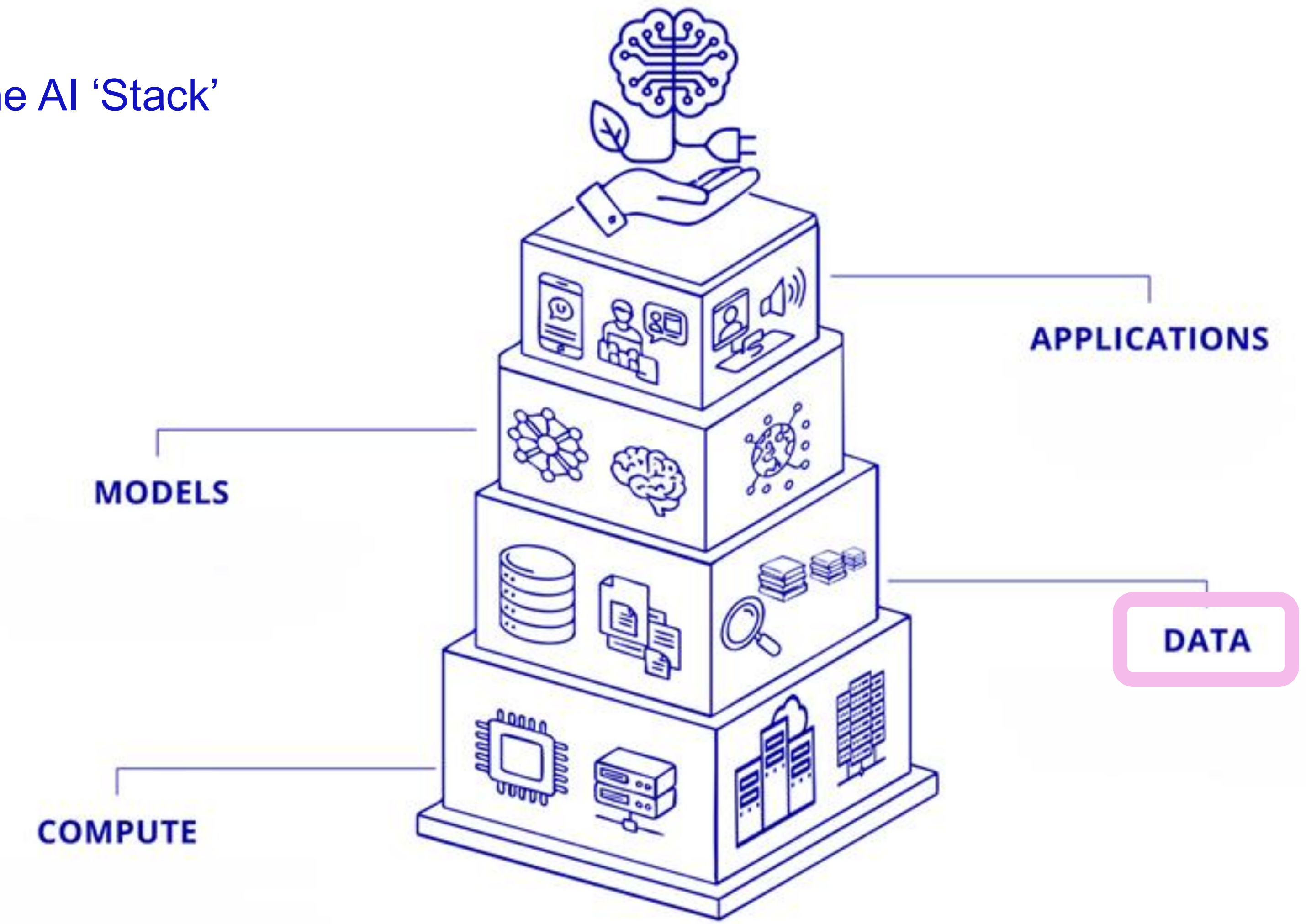

Open educational resources
Open source software and source code
Open research data
Scientific publications
Open hardware
Open scientific knowledge
Indigenous peoples
Open dialogue with other knowledge systems
OPEN PRACTICE
Open science infrastructures
Virtual
Marginalized scholars
Physical
Local communities
Open engagement of societal actors
Crowdfunding
Crowdsourcing
Scientific volunteering
Citizen and participatory science
VALUES
PRINCIPLES
Quality and integrity
Collective benefit
Equity and fairness
Diversity and inclusiveness
OPEN PRACTICE
Transparency, scrutiny, critique and reproducibility
Equality of opportunities
Responsibility, respect and accountability
Collaboration, participation and inclusion
Flexibility
Sustainability

The AI 'Stack'



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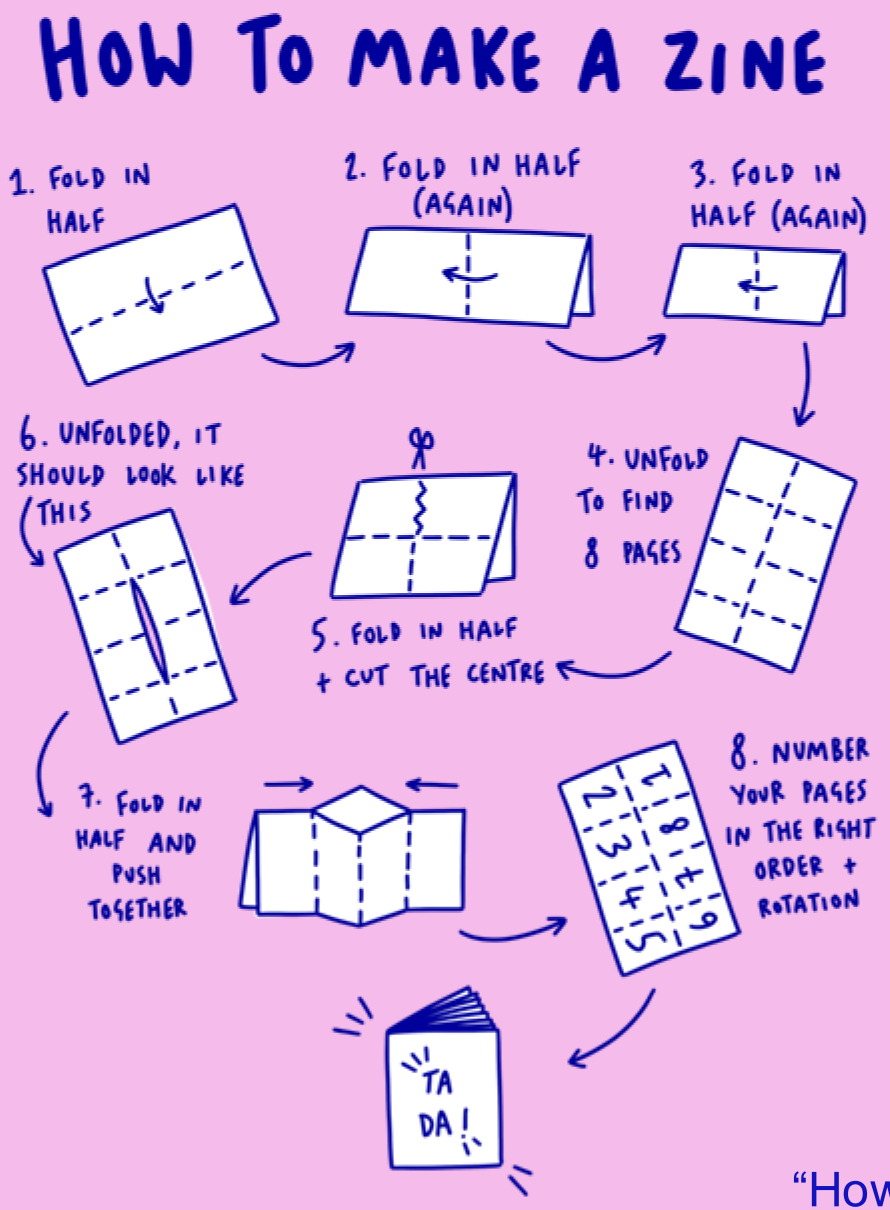


What principles speak to you? Which would promote justice and equity in your work?

Approaches and frameworks to help subvert the power dynamic of these systems

“How to make a zine” by Daisy Wakefield, 42nd Street Charity

CARE PRINCIPLES FOR INDIGENOUS DATA GOVERNANCE

- Indigenous data sovereignty
- Global Indigenous Data Alliance: https://www.gida-global.org/

- Designed to compliment the FAIR data principles
- Important to remember the origin and context (specifically indigenous data practices)

DATA FEMINISM

- **Examine power.** Data feminism begins by analysing how power operates in the world.
- **Challenge power.** Data feminism commits to challenging unequal power structures and working toward justice.
- **Elevate emotion and embodiment.** Data feminism teaches us to value multiple forms of knowledge, including the knowledge that comes from people as living, feeling bodies in the world.
- **Rethink binaries and hierarchies.** Data feminism requires us to challenge the gender binary, along with other systems of counting and classification that perpetuate oppression.
- **Embrace pluralism.** Data feminism insists that the most complete knowledge comes from synthesising multiple perspectives, with priority given to local, Indigenous, and experiential ways of knowing.
- **Consider context.** Data feminism asserts that data is not neutral or objective. It is the product of unequal social relations, and this context is essential for conducting accurate, ethical analysis.
- **Make labour visible.** The work of data science, like all work in the world, is the work of many hands. Data feminism makes this labour visible so that it can be recognised and valued.

Klein, Catherine D'ignazio And, Paola Verhaert, and Mushon Zer-Aviv. n.d. "The Seven Principles of Data Feminism." Responsible Data. Accessed June 11, 2026. https://responsibledata.io/anniversary/the-seven-principles-of-data-feminism/.

RESPONSIBLE DATA 101

- **Power dynamics**: The least powerful actors in any situation are often the first to see unintended consequences of data collected about them. Processes like co-designing or ensuring that people from diverse backgrounds are involved in data collection or analysis processes can mitigate against this.
- **Diversity and bias**: Considering questions like, “who makes the decisions? What perspectives are missing? How can we include a diversity of thought and approach?” can highlight blind spots, and areas where adding additional voices would be valuable.
- **Unknown unknowns**: We can’t see into the future, but we can build in checks and balances to alert us if something unexpected is happening.
- **Precautionary principle**: Just because we can use data in a certain way, doesn’t necessarily mean we should. If we can’t sufficiently evaluate the risk and understand the harms when handling data, then perhaps we should pause for a minute and re-evaluate what we’re doing and why.
- **Thoughtful innovation**: For new ideas to have the best possible chance of succeeding – and for everyone to benefit from those new ideas and projects – innovation needs to be approached with care and thought, not just speed.
- **Holding ourselves to higher standards**: In many cases, legal and regulatory frameworks have not yet caught up to the real-world effects of data and technology. How can we push ourselves to have higher standards and to lead by example?
- **Building better behaviours**: There is no one-size-fits-all for RD. Existing culture, context and behaviours change the implications and ways in which data is used.

WHAT KEY PRINCIPLE(S) DO YOU WANT TO APPLY TO ASSESSING THE ETHICS OF AI?

HOW MIGHT AI BE USED WITH CULTURAL COLLECTIONS?

1

AI for collections management and research

This includes applications that support description, discovery, cataloguing, access, preservation, and scholarly analysis.

2

AI for user engagement and access

This category focuses on how AI changes the way the public interacts with cultural heritage collections.

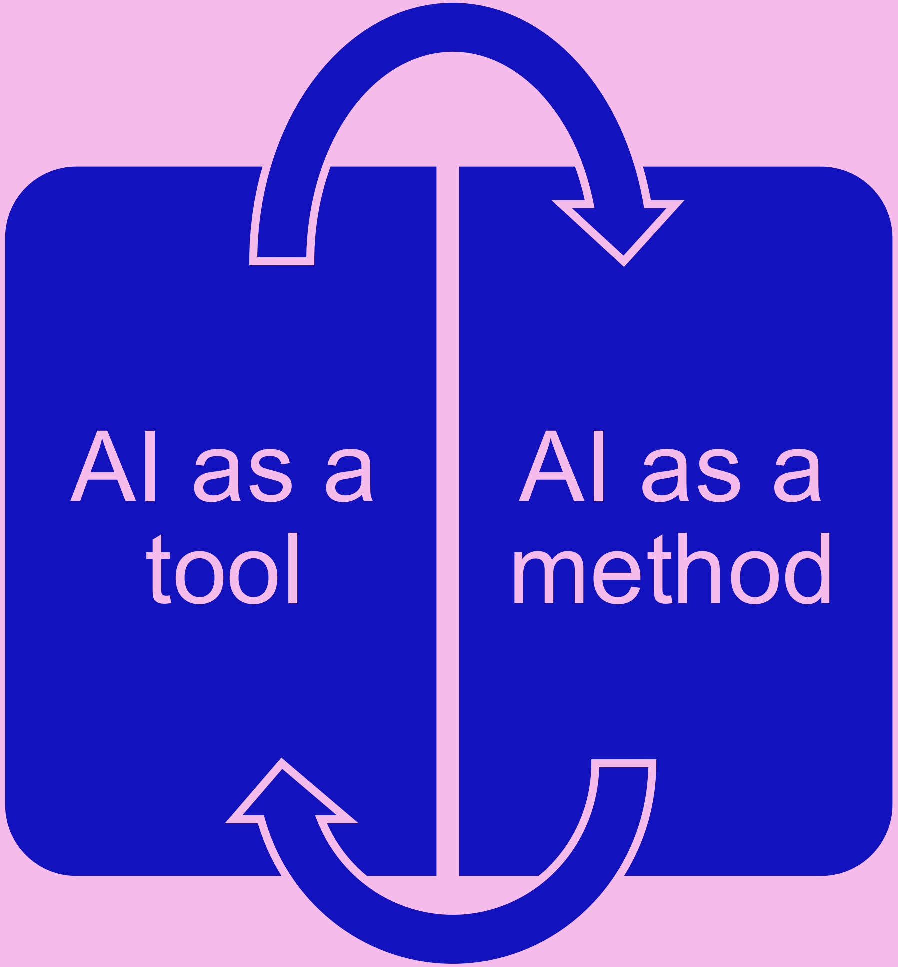
3

AI for general operations and management

This refers to ways in which AI contributes to the internal functioning of institutions.

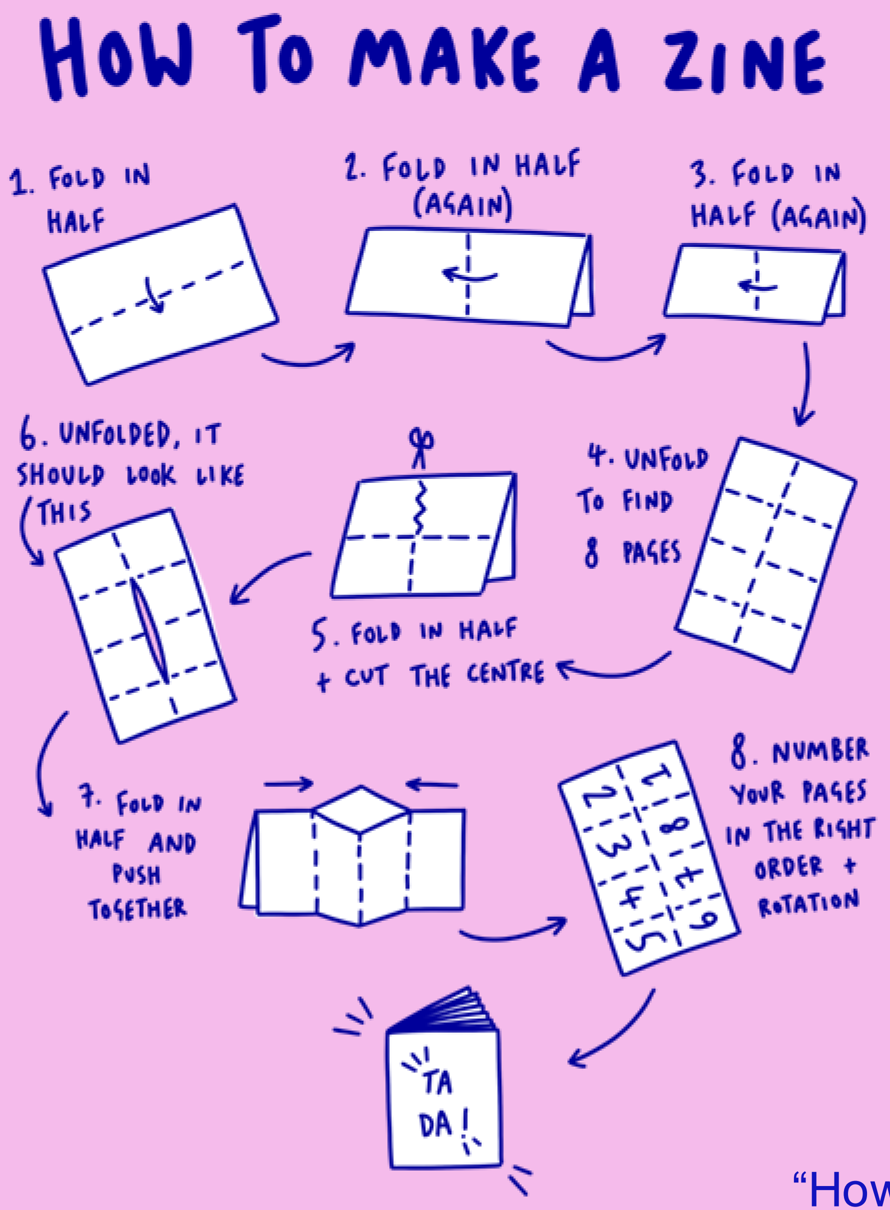
How will these uses be disclosed?
Who is held accountable for machine output?

- Use of ready-made systems to support existing workflows
    - Replicate existing curatorial methodologies
- Often commercial platforms with limited customisation
- Can be either specialised and focused or generic
- May not require* specialised knowledge of the AI method



- Design and use of AI models as a research methodology in and of itself
- For processing datasets that are too large or complex for human analysis
- Usually far more control/ability to customise
- Requires specialist computational knowledge of the AI method

- the tool *could* be used by someone without knowledge of the underlying model, not that is *should* be



Imagining futures
What might use of AI look like? Be specific
(Use 2 pages)

What specific applications of AI, or regulations around the use of AI, would you like to see, in an idealised future?

How would these modes of use subvert power structures and act along liberatory paths?

What forms of AI will be used? What forms will be discarded or restricted? How will use be disclosed? How will opting out be supported?

“How to make a zine” by Daisy Wakefield, 42nd Street Charity

	Applications	Models	Data	Compute	Collections management & research	User engagement & access	General operations & management
AI as a tool							
AI as a method							
Collections management & research							
User engagement & access							
General operations & management							

Using a matrix can help to assess where ethical concerns lie, where your practice sits at the intersection of the technology stack, the level of control you have over each underlying tech layer…

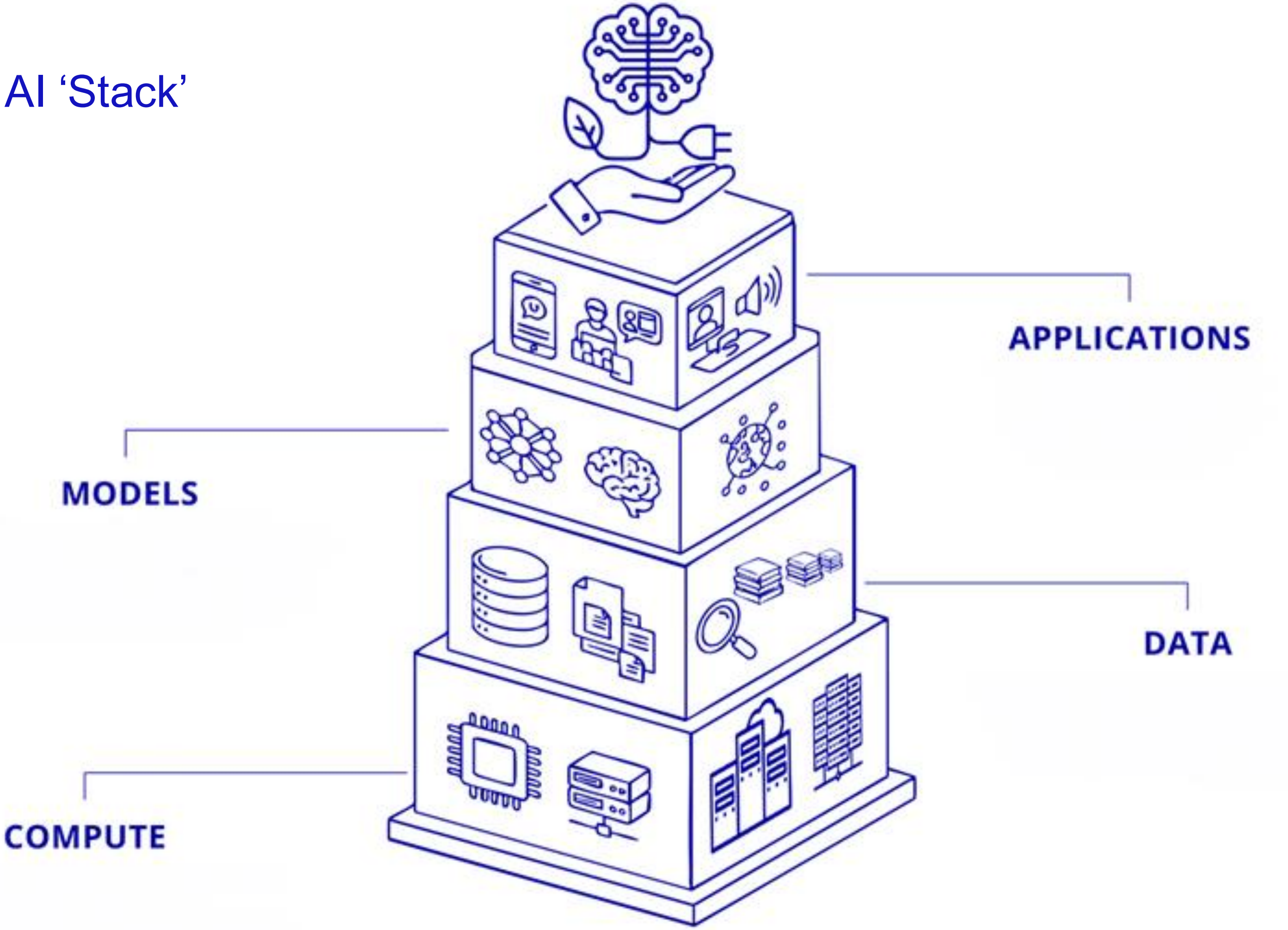
REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

- A series of questions that allow practitioners to consider different aspects of their work, how they may be upholding or reinforcing inequitable power structures, or amplifying inequalities and biases
- To be published openly – preregistration, in an open repository
- To be revisited as checkpoints throughout the project/use of the tool

REFLECTIVE QUESTIONS

- What is the problem that needs to be solved, and why do you think AI is necessary for this?
- How much decision-making or interpretation needs to be made/simulated by the AI model? (how granular is your workflow going to be?)
- Is there a specific, custom-made tool for this (e.g. an ML model trained and optimised for this specific application, made by experts in the domain), or will I need to use a generic, broad-but-shallow model (e.g. a proprietary LLM)?
- Has this tool been built with a framework/algorithm/training set that makes me believe that the inferences made will align with my ethical values? Who designed the model? Who does it serve?
- Can the process of decision-making or steps-to-output be made explicit and visible? (E.g. produces code vs answers; is the training set documented? How is the model tuned?)
- Do I have the technical skills or expertise to appropriately assess the output of the model?
- How will I disclose the use of AI and who assumes responsibility for failings?
- What are the specific risks or potential harms that this specific application of AI could pose? (e.g. harms of mislabelling/misidentifying people/objects in photographic collections, vs. incorrect code

The AI 'Stack'



	Applications	**Models**	**Data**	**Compute**	Collections management & research	User engagement & access	General operations & management
AI as a tool	X				X	X	X
AI as a method		X	X	X	X		
Collections management & research	X	X	X				
User engagement & access	X						
General operations & management	X						

WHAT KEY QUESTIONS WOULD YOU WANT INCLUDED IN THIS REFLECTIVE PROCESS?

Join at: **vevox.app**

ID: **171-059-007**

WHAT TOOLKIT/PROCESS/NEXT STEPS MIGHT HELP SUPPORT YOU APPLICATION OF ETHICAL AI?

Where do you fit?

When it comes to your feelings on the use of AI, where do you find yourself sitting?

Which figure in this drawing do you most relate to, and why?

Has this shifted?

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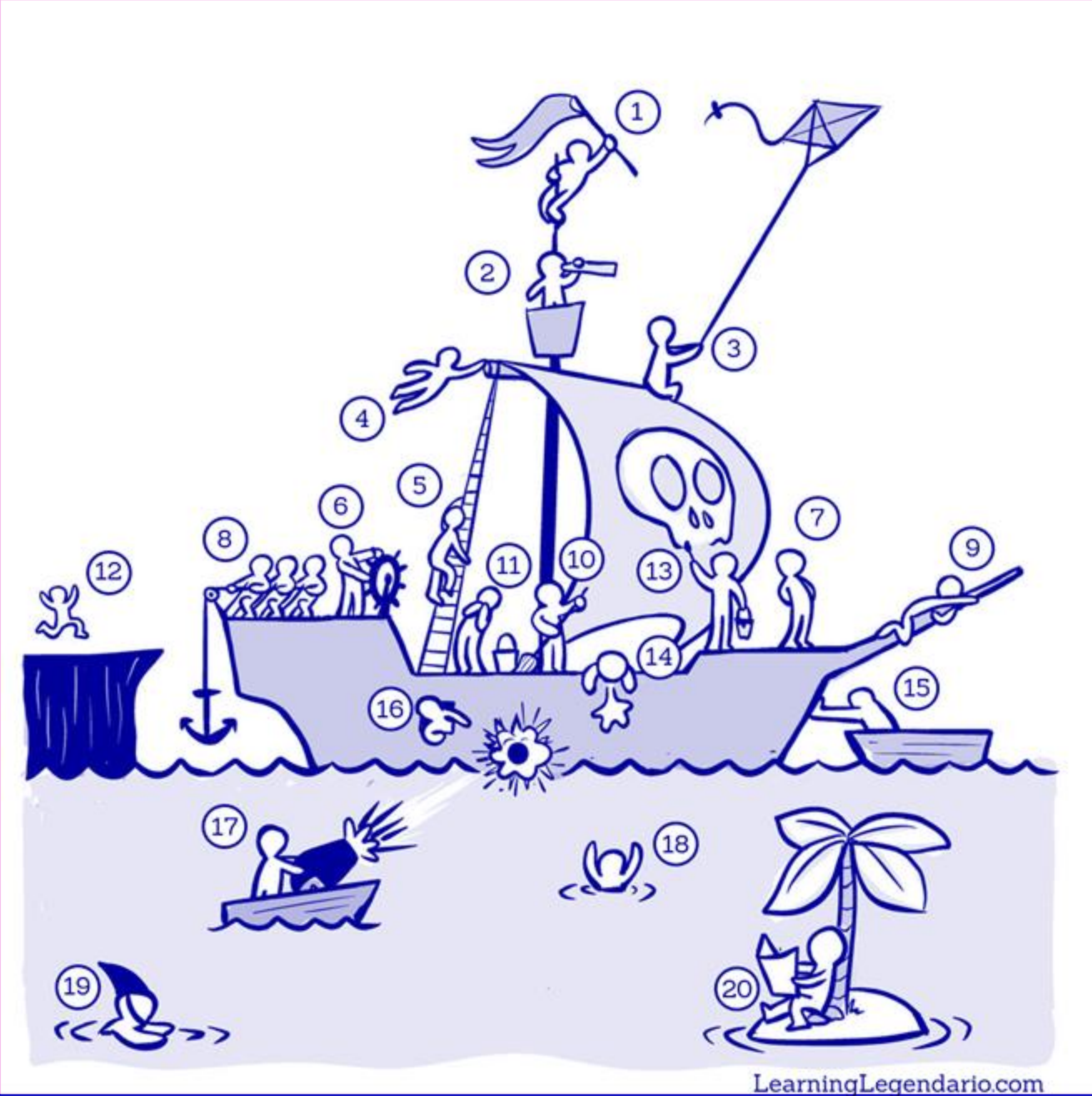

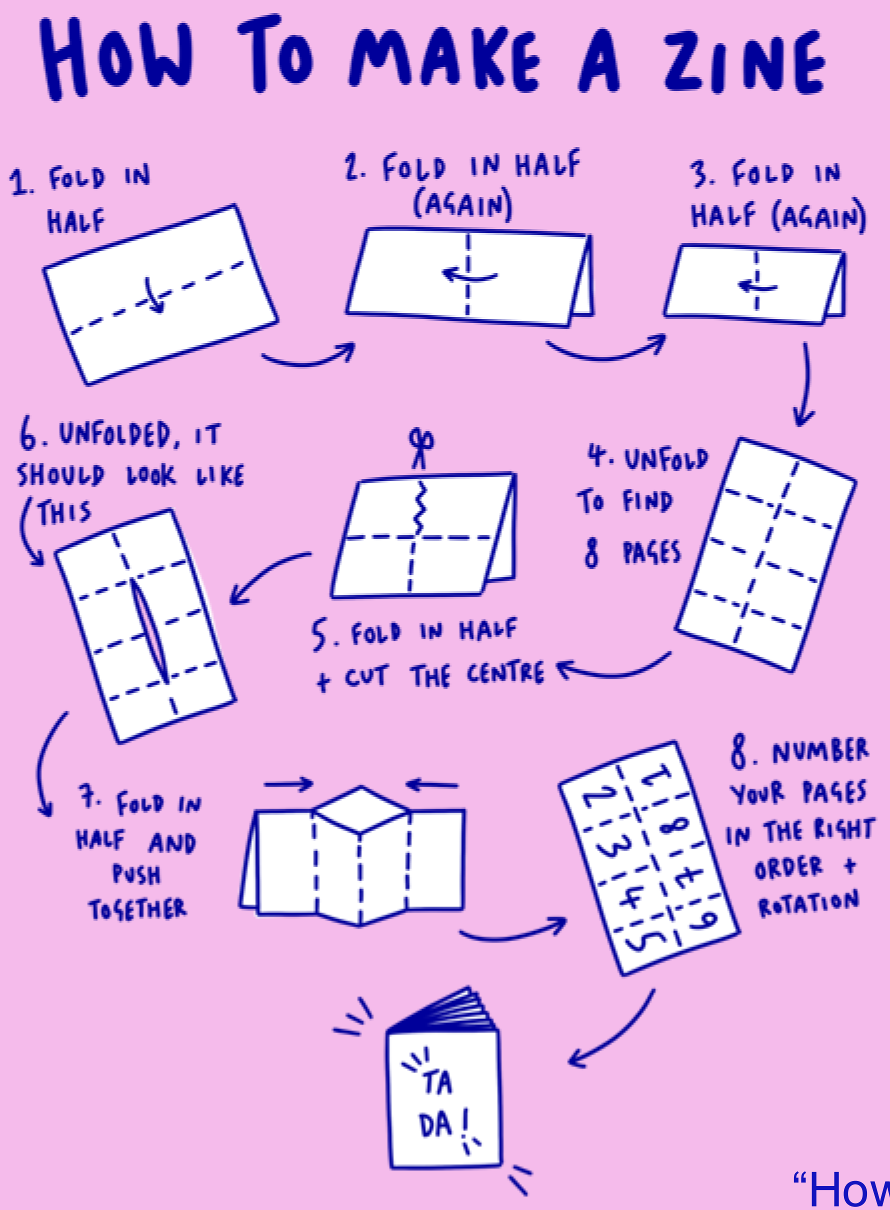

A call to action

What can you do next?

How can you collectively organise with the community to make these future ideas real?

Where do you think you can specifically focus your expertise and skills?

“How to make a zine” by Daisy Wakefield, 42nd Street Charity

COLLECTING THIS INTO A RESOURCE

BUILDING ON PREVIOUS WORK

- Searchable
- Atomised
- Using learnings from library resources and collections
- Building on existing case-studies

DEFINITIONS IN CONTEXT

- Specific forms of AI, their specific applications within a GLAM context
  - Specific ethical concerns for these applications of AI
- Provide a concrete example of harms and risks, make these open and transparent
- Interlinked

Essential for ethical application: a grounded, detailed, technical appreciation of the exact issues.

- Avoiding vague language
- Moving from the use of the term “AI” to specific sub-discipline applications
- Allows for comprehensive review of ethics: transparency

Computer Vision

- Image recognition
- Image classification
- Object detection
- Image segmentation
- Object tracking
- Scene understanding
- Facial recognition
- Pose estimation
- Optical character recognition
- Image generation
- Visual inspection

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- Image classification
- Object detection
- Image segmentation
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- **Scene understanding**
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- Image generation
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Computer Vision

- Image recognition
- Image classification
- Object detection
- Image segmentation
- Object tracking
- **<u>Scene understanding</u>**
- Facial recognition
- Pose estimation
- Optical character recognition
- Image generation
- Visual inspection

Scene understanding applications in Cultural Collections

- Generating image descriptions and alternative text
- Generating image categories metadata & grouping of images
- Generating image titles

Computer Vision

- Image recognition
- Image classification
- Object detection
- Image segmentation
- Object tracking
- **Scene understanding**
- Facial recognition
- Pose estimation
- Optical character recognition
- Image generation
- Visual inspection

Scene understanding applications in Cultural Collections

- **Generating image descriptions and alternative text**
- Generating image categories metadata & grouping of images
- Generating image titles

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Ethical concerns for *generating image descriptions and alternative text*

- Bias in training data and impact on accuracy of model
- Descriptions of people, cultures, clothing, activities, without context, nuance, and domain expertise
- Misgendering of subjects
- “Reviewer” using AI may encounter contested or harmful language generated by AI

Approaches, mitigations, managing these risks/harms

- Opt to not use AI
- Sovereign datasets: implementing data feminism
- Setting boundaries for classification:
    - Do not classify gender, ethnicity…
- Protections for practitioners: emotional engagement, recognition of embodiment in collections

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BUILDING ON PREVIOUS WORK

- Searchable
- Atomised
- Using learnings from library resources and collections
- Building on existing case-studies
- Equitable, editable, in flux:
  - Human infrastructure needed
  - Cannot depend on one single location
  - Justice work: often voluntary
  - Distributed, not a single point of control!